

and gastric bypass surgery outpaces inflation.⁶ And despite the growing body positivity movement (which is now just a marketing tactic to sell you products to “love” your body more), Ozempic, known generically as semaglutide, was Science.org’s 2023 Breakthrough Drug of the Year.⁷

Prescriptions for weight-loss drugs serve a necessary purpose on the market. But prescriptions for them have skyrocketed over the past five years. Semaglutide’s prescription rate nearly doubled in 2023 alone, while its competitor tirzepatide (Mounjaro and Zepbound) rose 141 percent. By the end of the year, all people could talk about was which of the injectables could help you lose weight faster. Without insurance, one dose of Ozempic retails for over \$900. The media reported that the only limit to how much these drug companies could earn was how fast they could crank them out. The industry is fueled by insecurities that knows its profits are driven by the fact that we don’t love ourselves as we are.

Ozempic isn’t the first diet craze to turn a profit from our insecurities, and it won’t be the last. You can replace “diet” with any product or service that manipulates natural and good desires. The beauty industry, skin-care industry, fashion industry, even the food industries are all guilty of manipulating our collective self-consciousness.

I was able to tell people my expensive gym membership and shipments of protein and pre-workout powders were because I wanted to be healthy, and while that wasn’t a lie, I knew it wasn’t the whole truth. I didn’t love my body, and I was spending real money to solve a manufactured problem.

Figuring out if you love something enough to buy it is a bumpy ride. You’ll get it right sometimes, but you’ll get it wrong a lot, especially at first. But there’s nothing you can buy, no outfit, organizer, planner, health craze, beauty procedure, trip, or experience that will make you good enough to love yourself if you don’t already. Until you choose to love yourself as you are, you will keep spending to gain your own approval. And in the end, with little to no savings, all you’ll be left with is another reason to be disappointed in yourself.

The sooner you realize that money can’t buy you who you want to be, the faster you’ll be able to figure out the things you love to buy because *you* love them. Not because of some made-up standard of beauty, career, parenting, or whatever. But because they matter to you, and you are valuable.